

The Unforgiving Servant

MEMORY VERSE

"As the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive." — Colossians 3:13 (ESV)

THE BIG IDEA

In the Parable of the Unforgiving Servant, a king forgives a servant an enormous debt he could never repay. But that same servant then refuses to forgive a fellow servant who owes him only a little, and has him thrown into prison. When the king hears, he is angry that the servant would not show the same mercy he had been given. Because God has forgiven us so much, Jesus teaches us to forgive others from the heart.

WHAT WE DID TODAY

We heard the story of the Unforgiving Servant from Matthew 18 and watched it come to life on video. We played a picture bingo game to get to know the people and moments in the parable, talked together about what happened, and each folded a paper cootie catcher full of questions about the story to bring home.

JESUS CONNECTION

We are like the servant who owed a debt we could never repay — our debt of sin. Jesus paid that debt for us on the cross, taking the punishment we deserved so that God could forgive us completely. When we really understand how much we have been forgiven, it changes how we treat others. Forgiving people isn't how we earn God's love; it flows out of hearts that know they have been forgiven.

FOLLOW UP AT HOME

TALK ABOUT IT

Chat together about how much the king forgave, and why it was so wrong for the servant not to forgive his friend. What does it mean to forgive someone from the heart? Talk about how God has forgiven us far more than anyone could ever owe us. You could ask each other: "Is there someone you need to forgive this week?"

TRY AT HOME

Read Matthew 18:21–35 together this week and thank God for forgiving you. Play with the cootie catcher your child made and answer the questions about the story together — a simple way to keep the parable going through the week.

